

The Savannah



THE SWEEPING GRASSLANDS of the African savannah are the last place on Earth where spectacular herds of large grazing animals still survive. There are two main seasons, wet and dry. At the start of the dry season, huge herds gather

together and make long journeys to find fresh grass and water. The migrating herds sometimes fill the plains as far as the eye can see.

Grazing animals feed mainly on grass. Grasses can survive this onslaught because they can grow from the base of their leaf blades. This means they can easily regenerate, even when animals eat the top of the grass. The plant-eaters themselves are a source of food for the hunters of the savannah—lions, leopards, cheetahs, and wild dogs. After a kill, scavengers move in to clean up the leftovers. Lizards, snakes, and millions of insects also live in the grasses of the Savannah.



Super soldier

Within a termite colony, there are “soldiers” that defend the colony from attack by enemies. A soldier uses its head and strong jaws to stab and wound attackers.

South African termite
(*Macrotermes natalensis*)
Length: up to 0.55 in (1.4 cm)



African savannah elephant
(*Loxodonta africana*)
Height at shoulder: up to 13 ft 1 in (4 m)
Trunk: up to 6 ft 6 in (2 m)

Giant eaters

African savannah elephants spend up to 16 hours a day searching for enough food to support their bodies. A big male can weigh as much as 90 adult people. Elephants use their long trunks to reach leaves high on the trees, and are strong enough to push over trees to reach the top branches.



Bone cruncher
Hyenas have massive jaws that are strong enough to crunch through bones. They hunt in small groups at night, killing animals such as wildebeest and zebra by disembowelling them. They also eat animals killed by other hunters.

Spotted hyena
(*Crocuta crocuta*)
Height at shoulder: up to 2 ft 8 in (81 cm)
Body length: up to 6 ft (1.6 m)



Blue wildebeest
(*Connochaetes taurinus*)
Height at shoulder: up to 5 ft 1 in (1.6 m)
Body length: up to 7 ft 10 in (2.4 m)

Tireless trekker

Wildebeest trek hundreds of miles across the savannah searching for fresh grass. Whenever they stop to rest or graze, each male stakes out a territory, which he guards against other males. Baby wildebeest can run soon after they are born, and in a few hours they are able to keep up with the rest of the herd.



Burchell's zebra
(*Equus quagga burchelli*)
Height at shoulder: up to 4 ft 7 in (1.4 m)
Body length: up to 8 ft (2.5 m)

Group protection

Zebras usually live in family groups, but in the dry season they gather in large herds. This helps protect them against enemies, since many pairs of eyes and ears are more likely to spot danger. Zebra stallions sometimes kick out at enemies, such as lions, and may smash their teeth.

Cheetah
(*Acinonyx jubatus*)
Body length: up to 4 ft 9 in (1.45 m)
Tail: up to 2 ft 6 in (76 cm)



Lightning cat

The cheetah relies on short bursts of incredible speed to catch its prey. It can sprint at more than 62 mph (100 kph) over short distances, but tires easily. It grips the throat of its prey with its long canine teeth and uses its razor-sharp back teeth to slice meat off of bones.

